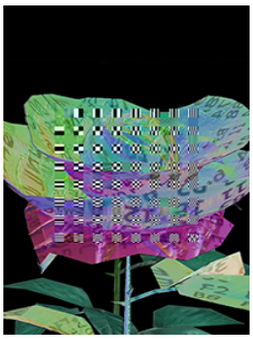

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THE INTELLIGENCE OF PLAYER HABITS AND REFLEXIVITY IN *MAGIC: THE GATHERING ARENA* LIMITED DRAFT

The queue of eight players being ready is marked with a resounding clang of cymbals. Following a brief "waiting for servers" notice, I am thrown into a different screen. Fourteen Magic: the Gathering (MTG) cards, neatly arranged, file from the right to the left of the screen with celerity. This is the digital equivalent of opening a pack of MTG cards. It is pack 1, pick 1 – the first of 42 picks. Immediately, I am drawn to the rare/mythic card at the top left corner. It is, disappointingly, Obscura Ascendancy. It is known as a "build-around" card: too many colours, too many conditions. Next, I look at the three uncommons. They're not the ones that I'm looking for but Riveteers Decoy is an "efficient" creature. Next, the commons. I see Hold for Ransom and proceed to wonder if "pacifism" style enchantment effects are good now. I remember that Pacifism in Ikoria had been terrible but also that Chord_O_-Calls had praised them in Crimson Vow. The other cards all appear to be middling and escape my notice. Yet as the timer ticks down, and without the gravitational pull of a strong card, I find my mind wandering as I entertain the possible sequence of events in which each of the commons shines. There isn't enough time to scry through these potentialities and I snap out of this reverie. I will pick Riveteers Decoy as a "safe bet" but will proceed to wonder what I had overlooked, what Chord or Sam Black would have picked. Numot, I'm sure, will undoubtedly have picked the Obscura Ascendancy (and done well with it).

introduction

Habits, despite the fact that they often evade our conscious awareness, can be considered to be the expression of, and the sedimentation of, intelligent action. John Dewey remarked that "in any intelligible sense of the word will, habits *are* will" (14), whilst Felix

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Ravaisson averred that habits exercise an intelligence "dispersed throughout the body and indeed throughout nature as a whole" (Carlisle and Sinclair 11–12). Thus, if we follow Ravaisson and Dewey, it may be said about habits that they *are* will and they *are* intelligence. By intelligence, I refer to the capacity for action or behaviour that unfolds in line with goals, projects, needs, as well as being able to adapt these (Miyahara and Robertson; Levy). What is parsed and then excluded or ignored by this intelligence can be said to be "noise"; these are the stimuli that are of no interest to the habituated individual, that do not trigger or activate their habits. Indeed, they have been habitually filtered out. However, insofar as habits are themselves mutable, what is excluded in such a fashion is itself being constantly recalibrated. At this point, we have perhaps shifted from habit to what many philosophers and sociologists refer to as "reflexivity" (see Stiegler, *Taking Care* 135).

If habit as "intelligence" is taken to be a particular means of organizing and processing information, such that it is a method of sorting: into information that is useful, on the one hand, and that which can be disregarded as "noise," on the other, then "reflexivity" would be the means by which intelligence doubles back and reflects on its own operation. Inherent in this notion of reflexivity is the possibility of that operation being consequently changed or transformed. It is a self-scrutinization that opens into a recalibration, which then leads to further recursive re-iterations of the same. Such a capacity for reflexivity has traditionally been celebrated by philosophers who have fulminated against the so-called perfidiousness of settled habits acquired through non-conscious sedimentation, which must be overcome as a limitation on the autonomy of the self. Wormald has branded these the so-called "thinkers of subject"; the most eminent of which are Descartes, Kant, and Sartre. The capacity for reflexivity in overcoming habits has in this way been seen to be central to our freedom and autonomy.

In this paper, I argue that the way in which players adapt their gameplay through reflexivity is a process that can be understood as distributed in habit assemblages, which enable *particular* reflexive techniques. My starting point here is the question: "how are we reflexive in gameplay?" Another way of asking this may be: "how do we reflect on what we do within a game?" or, "how do we problematize our existing approach to a law-governed complex system (often, this is a game), in a manner that seeks to transform that approach to one that is better suited to meeting our aims?" I will argue against a view of reflexivity that would seek to elevate it as a transcendental capacity innate to all of us.[1] Such a view accords insufficient specificity to the ways in which particular "forms of reflexivity" arise (Foucault, *Hermeneutics* 460), and which are exercised in connection with particular "habit assemblages" (Bennett et al. 12). This enables us to focus on the specific characteristics of the form of reflexivity at stake: what it can identify or single out in order to reflect upon (and what it cannot), what it can permit to disrupt existing regimes of practice (and what it does not), and what it holds as the *telos* of its own operation.

My study is centred on how players of *Magic: The Gathering Arena* play the limited draft format. In particular, I will be using streamer Chord_O_Calls' reflections in his instructional video as a means of illuminating how players exercise reflexivity over their own gameplay, how they consciously and non-consciously apply classification schemas and heuristics as filters for the cards that they pick and how they come to reflect on their own application. To wit, it concerns the way in which players problematize their own style of play and turn it into an object of knowledge.[2] I will argue that the MTG habit assemblage is a set of techniques or technologies that shape, but do not determine, the manner in which individual players problematize their own play – the form of reflexivity that they engage in.[3] It enables, for "mastery-oriented players" like Chord (Karhulahti), a form of reflexivity that comes from the individual's practice-based synthesis of game paratexts (Consalvo, "When Paratexts Become Texts"; Apperley and Walsh) and their own gaming experiences via

practices that can be identified as: a vigilant hermeneutics of self-examination; a relentless trial by gameplay; a studious attentiveness to new theories; an experimental attitude to gameplay; and a critical parsing of data. The result is what I call an incessant "re-habituation" of one's MTG "gamer habitus." The complexity and variance involved in MTG limited draft means that it can be far from obvious to players whether aspects of their play need to be problematized, if at all, since some drafts will be better or worse than others due to factors beyond a player's control. The difficulty inherent in codifying good practices foments a vigilance in the face of complexity that can be rather open in its exact form, which also means a degree of openness in the kind of self-constitution or re-habituation that is involved – this is a primary driver of my interest here. Although the conclusions that will be drawn here will be with regard to what I call the "MTG habitus" as it pertains to limited draft, I will expound upon the broader socio-technical significance of the reflexivity in question at the end of this paper.

the limited format

The game, MTG limited draft, as well as the "habit assemblage" around it, is particularly notable for how players must continuously recalibrate and transform their approach to drafting due to an evolving understanding of the format and the metagame. *Magic: The Gathering* (Wizards of the Coast, 1993), as played on *MTG: Arena* (Wizards of the Coast, 2018) is a game that requires players to continuously *re*-habituate (Zhu, "Ambivalence") their own acquired playing dispositions and approach to drafting due to an evolving understanding of the format and the metagame (Boluk and LeMieux). Although almost all multiplayer games feature changing metagames of some sort, the complexity of various MTG limited formats makes this recalibration process especially pronounced. Players undergo a dynamic process of, firstly, conscious reflection – in which players turn their own playing style or disposition into an "object of knowledge" to be examined and reworked; and secondly, a non-conscious internalization of a different playing disposition (cf. Carlisle). Such a process bears many similarities to what Crossley calls "reflexive body techniques" ("Circuit Trainer's Habitus"). My focus here will be on the particular form of reflexivity or conscious reflection as to one's own gameplay approach as shaped by certain techniques and technologies. The official launch of MTG Arena in 2019, a popular digital version of MTG, has coincided with the arrival of various resources that have altered how players engage with the game, including, for example, the 17lands.com tracker. These technologies have led to wide-ranging impacts on how the limited draft format is thought about and explored; they constitute an MTG "habit assemblage."

Drafting or booster drafting is a *limited* format, which means that it is defined by the *limitations* on the cards that one can play: players may only play with the cards that they pick in a draft. The drafting process itself is precisely bound by rules. There are eight players in a draft who take simultaneous turns to pass cards to one another one by one (see Trammell). Each player starts with three unopened packs. To begin, the first pack is opened; each player takes one card from it and then passes the rest to the player on their left. Players continue to take one card and pass the remainder until all the cards in the first pack are exhausted. The second pack is then opened and the same process repeated, albeit players pass to their right. Finally, the third pack is opened. This time, players pass to their left once again. By the end of pack three, players will normally have around forty-two cards from which to build their deck. In this drafting process, there is an admixture of information that is revealed (what you have opened and have passed, and what you have been passed) and information that is hidden (the cards that other individual players have taken). Players must infer what other players are drafting from the cards that are passed to them – known as reading the "signals."

The limited format is high in *chance* and in *complexity*. The launch of each new format is first characterized by a sense of exploration as

three hundred or so new cards, each with different mechanics, are gradually understood by players for what they do and for their possible interactions with the other cards. Competitive players will need to know all three hundred or so cards and to have some sense of the emergent archetypes that arise from them. They will need to consider a range of questions that do not necessarily admit any guaranteed answers, such as: Which cards are powerful in their own right? Which cards synergize well with other cards? Which deck archetypes fare better than others? Playing well calls for more than mere preparedness, however, since improvisation and being flexible to what's available – what is (and is not) being passed to you – are also central. Players cannot simply pick the strongest card that is passed to them, but must keep in view a matrix of factors: the "synergy" between their existing cards; the possibility of certain cards being passed to them in the future; the "curve" of their deck; the balance of card types in their deck; the nature of the format; the decks that they will likely face; the colours and decks that other players at the table are drafting; the extent to which they would like to test a new strategy; their own playstyle and ability to pilot the deck that could be drafted; and many others. The possible permutations in drafting and deckbuilding (not to mention the play itself) are innumerable.

gamer habitus in the mtg draft metagame

The complexity in the permutations of drafting and deckbuilding means that players will be involved in an ongoing change to their evaluations of individual cards and strategies. This results in a changing or evolving *metagame*. By "metagames" here I mean how players *consciously* evaluate and draft cards *in response* to the progressive identification of strategies/archetypes/counter-strategies and how this produces an *evolving* environment for limited draft (see Boluk and LeMieux 230). In Boluk and LeMieux's acclaimed book, *Metagaming*, they give at least fifteen definitions of metagames/metagaming. I am deliberately taking a less expansive view here than one of the most expansive ones that they cite, which was offered by MTG creator Richard Garfield: "how a game interfaces outside of itself," as it potentially encompasses everything outside of the formal rules of the game. The more modest sense already captures how players change their decisions in the knowledge of the decisions that others are likely to make (at a given point in time), which is based on one's understanding of the viable strategies that any player could pursue.

It is important to underscore here, however, that the way in which we draft and play MTG is not only due to *conscious* gameplay strategies or decisions. It is also due to our *non-conscious* judgements, dispositions, inclinations of play; it arises from the way in which we exercise our instincts and intuitions. There is no truly self-evident optimal means that MTG players can employ to evaluate the cards that they are drafting as a matter of rule. There are merely degrees of consensus among professional players as to what an optimal means may be that are liable to shift over time. It is important not to overlook that the way that individuals play and draft will likely be shaped by the accumulated experience that they bring to a new set, the particularities of which will vary according to each. This dimension cannot be entirely captured in the definition of "metagame" given above.

Such a dimension can be referred to as a "gamer habitus." Kirkpatrick has defined the "gamer habitus" as "the socially acquired, embodied dispositions that ensure someone knows how to respond to a computer game" that is attained through experience (19). It foregrounds the non-conscious skills and dispositions that enable an individual to "unlock" the pleasurable experiences and rhythms of gaming – the player's hands are able to enter the requisite inputs so that they are not staring down helplessly at their controller whilst being overwhelmed on screen. He explored how a gamer habitus was first formed in the years after 1985, when gaming began to be established as a cultural "field" (Bourdieu, *Field*), or arena of practice with its

own distinctive rules, knowledges, and forms of capital. Gaming magazines standardized a gaming discourse, individuals identified themselves as gamers, and movements of the hands began to be standardized (see Consalvo, *Cheating*). Kirkpatrick's concept evidently draws upon Bourdieu's notion of "habitus": the "habitus" is an individual's non-conscious schema of perception, classification, and appreciation. For Bourdieu (*Logic* 53), an individual's habitus is their inarticulable "practical reason" that "biases their implicit micro-anticipations of the kind of world that we will encounter at each moment" (Lizardo 406); it is, in this way, a non-determining "principle" for their actions that is not consciously known to them nor cognitively governed through an exhaustive list of reasons (Wacquant, "Habitus" 24). Bourdieu underscored its *non-conscious* nature; habitus operates as the "unchosen principle of all choices" guiding practices that assume the systematic character of strategies even though they are not the result of strategic intention and are objectively "orchestrated without being the product of the organizing activity of a conductor" (Wacquant, "Concise" 67).

Other authors have used different terms for similar concepts to that of "gamer habitus."[4] What most of these definitions attend to are the embodied somatic skills that enable computer game players to enter time-critical inputs into controllers, how they do this non-consciously, and how they come to acquire the capacity to do so. Yet what has received comparatively less attention are practices in *non-time-critical* games, such as MTG. Here, I am interested in the way in which habitus *disposes* one to certain modes or patterns of "thinking," reasoning, judging in MTG that are not so directly tied into movements of the player's body.[5] Although thinking and reasoning *are* embodied, there are significant differences between players' dispositions in non-time-critical TCGs (trading card games) and their embodied skills in time-critical games. Time-critical inputs are irrelevant in *MTG: Arena*. A broader point here concerns how we conceptually manage the scope of the gaming dispositions in question. Given the popularity of MTG as a TCG, which has heavily influenced various subsequent TCGs, together with the existence of a lively community that sustains particular practices and an MTG gaming discourse, it seems appropriate to talk about a "MTG gamer habitus." This is not, however, necessarily to imbue it with a strong sense of autonomy that brackets it off from all other gaming practices; players of MTG limited draft will undoubtedly find it easier to learn *Hearthstone's* (Blizzard Entertainment, 2014) Arena draft mode (and vice versa), for example.[6]

In the next section, I turn to a case study which shows how an expert player comes to problematize his own gameplay habitus. What is revealing about this process is the manner in which his gameplay habitus becomes identified as an "object of knowledge." Through a form of reflexivity, there is a certain way in which it becomes, first, conceivable for him and then second, seen as being in need of a very specific kind of transformation.

chord_o_calls' big picture thoughts

Streamer Alex Nikolic, known as Chord_O_-Calls, makes guide to drafting videos for his YouTube channel, Limited Level-Ups, in which he reviews a format a few weeks into it. He calls these "big picture thoughts." These are for students that he coaches but also for any viewer looking to improve their game. Viewers watch to glean the emerging patterns that he has noticed such that they may adjust their play, fine-tune their own approach to the format. In a video concerning the Crimson Vow limited format (VOW), Chord took some time to reflect on the role of "removal" (cards that destroy creatures or render them unable to attack).[7] He specifically singled out the overperformance of the card "Sigarda's Imprisonment" (Figure 1). It is what may be called a "pacifism effect" (similar to the card "Pacifism" in that it does not remove the targeted creature from play but merely renders it unable to block or attack). Such cards had long been deemed to be sub-par removal, to be avoided for the most part. As he explicitly mentioned, this was a general consensus

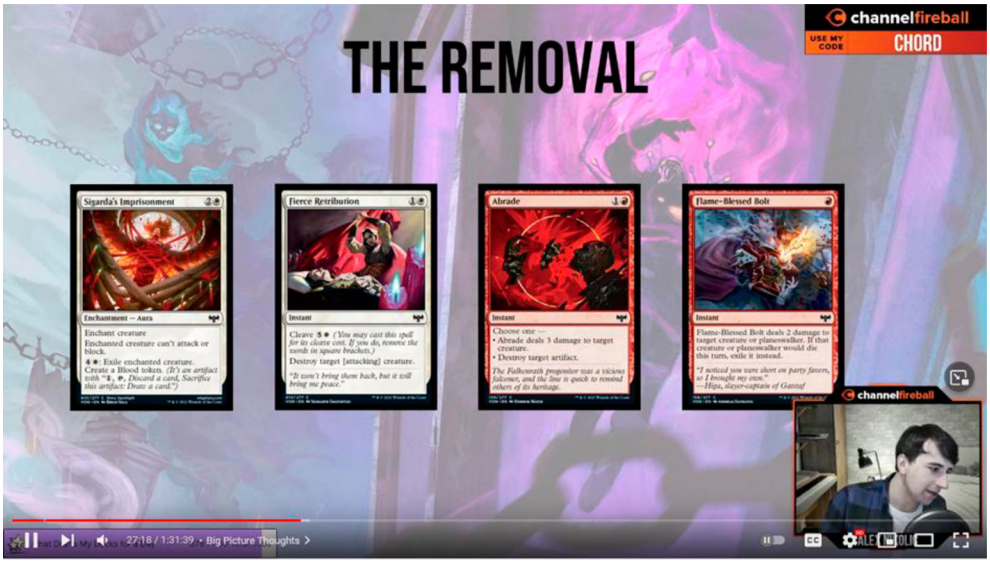


Fig. 1. Chord's "big picture thoughts" (image taken from "Draft Lessons from Crimson Vow | Limited Level-Ups Episode 76" with the creator's permission).

among many expert players with, as Chord notes, the Lords of Limited (Ben Werner and Ethan Saks), Limited Resources (Luis Scott-Vargas and Marshall Sutcliffe), and Sam Black, as well as Alex himself, among them. These players had all been encouraging their viewers and listeners to stay away from "pacifism effects" for many years.

Chord's overall position for the past five years had been to advise viewers to take removal less highly in the draft and to prioritize cheap, especially two-mana, creatures. This was the approach or heuristic that he brought with him to playing Crimson Vow. He calls this "your baseline." This is a series of heuristic shortcuts that enable one to navigate the complexity of MTG drafts – it helps one make the forty-two picks in a draft by regulating the cards that stand out and those that are filtered out from consideration. This baseline is not necessarily a set of rules that can be articulated precisely in their entirety, since there will likely be many contextual exceptions that he and other players would subscribe to. Further, it takes into account one's own play preferences; a player inclined to draft more aggressive decks will likely have a different baseline from one who prefers to draft control decks. It is, I argue, a self-articulation of one's MTG gamer habitus; it is a set of guiding principles that do not exhaust the non-conscious dispositions which may decide the way that the action is actually done in its specific context.

Yet despite being an expert player with a clearly thought-out baseline, he admitted to struggling with winning games in Crimson Vow. He believes that this changed, however, once he started taking removal more highly. Consequently, he tries to puzzle out why this might be, since it runs *contrary* to years of his accumulated experience and to his playing instincts. Sigarda's Imprisonment, in particular, was not only removal but also removal of the pacifism kind – doubly dubious on Chord's previous baseline. Nevertheless, its overperformance was eventually revealed to him through his navigation of VOW, based on 17lands.com data compiled from players, his chats with other players, and his own gameplay experiences. In trying to make sense of it, he listed several possible reasons, such as: it is removal that exiles (relevant in a set with graveyard recursion); White has few other ways of getting a Blood Token; and it deals with the

many threatening bombs in the set. Arguably, however, verbalized reasons still cannot add up to adequately explain the "feel" that a player gets. Concurrently, he found that another one of his "baselines" was presenting problems. Chord had also previously declared that "you can never have enough good two drops" (two-mana creatures). Yet most two drops ended up being outclassed in VOW – they did not make enough of an impact before they were rendered redundant by higher mana creatures. Ultimately, he advises viewers to be "willing to shift your baseline," one's fundamental way of thinking and evaluating. He presents this as a general lesson for becoming a better MTG player – having the flexibility to know when one's baselines are serving poorly in a format and adapting them accordingly. Within the specific context, this may entail accepting that "pacifism effects" as creature removal might be good, and that many two drops should be avoided.

object of knowledge and the re-habituation of one's gamer habitus

I argue that what we see here is the manner in which a player turns their own approach to drafting, their own gamer habitus in this regard, into an "object of knowledge" or enquiry – their "baseline." Chord had engaged in a process whereby he pondered the possible connections between his approach to drafting VOW, his previous baseline, and his lack of success in the format. He had drawn a causal connection between the two. His introspection here is representative of what many players do when they approach a new format and attempt to evaluate their lack of success. It is by *formulating and identifying a connection between one's gamer habitus and one's lack of success*, that one can then transform one's fortunes in the new format. It is by self-reflexively bringing all of this to conscious awareness, constituting it in thought, that marks the first step to knowing what to do differently (see Noble and Watkins; Crossley, "Circuit Trainer's Habitus").

In this way, a player re-evaluates their existing valuation of cards. Those that were once overlooked (like "pacifism effects") might come to assume a weightier appraisal, and vice versa. This reflexivity is a dynamic, recursive process, one that may try to include what had previously been excluded – an intelligence that reconsiders what is excluded as noise. Players may subsequently come to re-evaluate cards that they had previously ignored as low priority draft picks; these might then come from the periphery to the forefront of their attention. This is an ongoing process that is continuously informed by subsequent experiences. My short account of one of my own draft experiences (for the SNC format) at the outset of this paper illustrates the orientation of my own MTG gamer habitus; it is one that exercises a degree of caution in avoiding high risk high return cards like Obscura Ascendancy, and which leans towards tried and tested creature-based decks that seek to eke out value in the mid-game through good cards and good plays. In my reverie, I was aware of certain alternative picks in the pack but could only wonder at the possibilities that I had not considered, yet which may well later emerge as archetypes perfected by streamers. Those cards that are low in my pick order, although I was well-aware of their mechanics, did not necessarily reveal their full potential as a piece within an archetype to me due to my specific MTG gamer habitus.

There are knock-on effects here to shifting one's baseline. If your limited deck's two-mana or three-mana slots now have a higher number of removal cards, then that will coincide with a reduction in creatures, which will then shift you further towards a "control" strategy. Games will likely take longer; it will be harder to pressure an opponent's life total early on. The very dynamics of how a deck aims to achieve victory are likely profoundly changed. In this way, given that the baseline of how Chord "understands" VOW has shifted and given the knock-on effects, we can speculate that consequences may flow from this following a period of playing in accordance with the new baseline. It is possible that the

baseline of how he thinks about the limited draft format in MTG *beyond* that of playing the metagame in any particular set, like VOW, may also have changed through the non-conscious sedimentation of gameplay practices that are more centred on removal and less on two drops: conscious identification in VOW leads to a non-conscious sedimentation for future drafts (see Malabou).

MTG is a game that is defined by a unique configuration of continuity and change; some cards in each new set are likely to bear strong resemblances to cards that players of MTG have already encountered in previous sets. As such, players' evaluations of these new cards are likely to be informed by their accumulated experiences from playing with and against those older cards from previous sets. Therefore, when players revise their style of play and change their preferences for cards, there is arguably a revision of not only how they see the metagame in the new set, but also, to a certain extent, a transformation in how they generally understand the limited draft format in MTG. In this way, MTG players are involved in re-habituating their own acquired playing dispositions (Zhu, "Ambivalence"). I use "re-habituate" here to evoke the way in which the revision is not merely to that of a consciously chosen approach – a change from one set of consciously held, articulable beliefs about the metagame to another. It can amount to a shift to one's accumulated habitual orientation to the game of MTG limited draft.

problematization and forms of reflexivity

Bringing *non-conscious* dispositions into *conscious* awareness to be reworked can be understood to be a form of self-reflexiveness or reflexivity. In the literature on habitus, it has received attention from scholars who have looked into sports training, such as how one unlearns "bad" tennis habits in order to relearn better ones advised by one's coach; and it is also a point frequently made by scholars who critique Bourdieu for not according enough emphasis on how agents can consciously work on their habitus (Noble and Watkins; Crossley, "Phenomenological"). Noble and Watkins have argued that there are various levels of awareness – reflection, attention, and practical sense, in analytic and synthetic modes – that are mobilized in the development of bodily capacities and their sedimentation into habitus. There is a to-and-fro between conscious learning and then "forgetting" as the movements become non-conscious, together with checking and remembering as techniques are reflected upon and revised. Bourdieu's discussion of the moments in which an individual's habitus can be out of synch with the social "field" – the "hysteresis effect" – seemed not to foreground micro-mutations as part of everyday life (Strand and Lizardo). For example, he claimed that reflexivity *only* emerges "in situations of crisis which disrupt the immediate adjustment of habitus to field" (Bourdieu, *In Other Words* 108). The critiques of the overly demanding conditions of Bourdieusian reflexivity are welcome but I also propose that they often resort to invoking a transcendental capacity for reflexivity inherent in us, in our ability to rework our sedimented dispositions, rather than in underscoring the specificity of the socio-technical context which enables a certain form of reflexivity.

In order to understand the self-reflexivity operative here, I take inspiration from Foucault to consider this as a "*problematization*" of the player's play style as a practice. Foucault says that as a historical phenomenon, problematization is that movement by which thought detaches itself from what one does, "establishes it as an object and reflects on it as a problem" for which "one proposes diverse practical solutions" ("Polemics" 388–89). This approach differs from either a history of ideas or a history of behaviours because its focus is the work of thought upon itself: its object of study is the field of continuous exchange between these two domains. It identifies the history of "the way people begin to take care of something, of the way they became anxious about this or that" (Foucault, *Fearless Speech*

74). The inducement of a "crisis" in previously silent behaviour is an apt description for how we have conceived of reflexivity upturning an established gamer habitus, or how "thought detaches itself from what one does" in the way players seek to improve. Further, the notion of "anxiety" and "care" marks out a motivational *telos* for the desiring subject. With the MTG gamer habitus, however, we are concerned with problematization not in terms of epistemic shifts or discernible social crises but the everyday micro-actions through which an individual cares for the cultivation of their gamer habitus. These practices and problematizations take place in the domain or field of gaming, of chance, of leisure time, of play, of aims/goals/expectations that the player has about the activity.

Foucault's is notably a *genealogical* approach to the analysis of reflexivity. Given that it does not assume a universal capacity for reflexivity that we exercise in a similar fashion regardless, it allows us to be discerning with respect to the *kind* of reflexivity that it is, and the social and cultural context in which it takes place. For him, different kinds of introspection or forms of reflexivity that have been practised throughout history. From Antiquity, Foucault had explored various transformative practices including: Epictetus on *skholastikos*, which called for the exercise of systematically examining one's opinions (in order to select those to discard and those to retain); Plato on *epistrophē*, which was a turning away from appearances (an awakening in which the soul returns to its source); and Marcus Aurelius on *héauto-scopie*, a form of self-viewing (a particular method for vigilant self-scrutinization). These practices were birthed from different problematizations. Indeed, he has declared that the history of the care of the self begins "with an analytics of the forms of reflexivity, inasmuch as it is the forms of reflexivity that constitute the subject as such" (Foucault, *Hermeneutics* 462).

With Chord, he had considered his way of approaching drafting Crimson Vow, replete with all of its conscious and non-conscious assumptions, all his sedimented dispositions from decades of playing MTG. This was brought out as an object of knowledge – it was constructed or created by him in a certain way, as his "baseline" – in order that it could be problematized by him and later transformed. In an analogous manner to how an individual's sexual conduct could be seen to solicit their moral concern and to call for an active ongoing care of the self (see Bogue 5), so could one's care and concern be directed towards one's approach to the MTG draft. What had prompted this problematization was an unsatisfactory win ratio. The *telos* of one's care could thus be considered to be to maximize this ratio, to climb up the ranks, to acquire greater in-game rewards as a result of wins, to regard oneself as an accomplished MTG drafter and player.

habit assemblages

Whilst the Foucauldian theoretical framework *does* enable relational considerations of the role of non-human actants (Lemke), there are also certain limitations that may prompt the necessity of "working from Foucault after Foucault" (Massumi 158). *Pace* Stiegler's notion of "exteriorization," we can hold that consciousness has always been exteriorized into its material technical supports (Roberts 60). That is to say, I argue that the forms of reflexivity germane to MTG players are socio-technically constituted through the practices or techniques that players use to engage with available technologies. What results is amenable to being read in terms of "habit assemblages" or "mind–body–environmental assemblages" (Bennett et al. 12). An assemblage can be thought to be a contingent ensemble of things, practices, and relations that, although appearing as a functioning whole, is not reducible to a single logic. John Dewey's work had notably underscored how habits are produced through the "cooperation of an organism and an environment," as "working adaptations of personal capacities with environing forces" (10). This sees habits (and reflexivity) as *distributed*. It also considers habits, as Pedwell reminds us, as "a range of capacities

for 'intelligent' action made possible not through disembodied reason but rather via ongoing interactions of bodily processes, cognitive functions and environmental conditions" (68). The notion of habit assemblages thus links together organisms, objects, (infra)structures, and atmospheres into an "ecology of operations" (Geoghegan).

This is a genealogical approach to thinking how particular forms of reflexivity exist in relation to specific habit assemblages. In the next part, I will examine the issue of the *manner* in which individual players may engage with the assemblage. We will see that gameplay practice is crucial to establishing the way in which players may problematize their gamer habitus within a changing metagame.

the technologies or techniques that identify the object of knowledge

How then, exactly, does a player turn their gamer habitus into an object of knowledge or thought? The *motivation* to do so may come, as it did with Chord, from a dissatisfaction with one's win ratio and a desire to improve it. This can be regarded as the *telos*, the mode of being to which the subject aspires (Foucault, *History*). The precise manner in which one consciously constitutes one's gamer habitus, together with a proposed change to it, comes from a complex *practice-based synthesis* of various elements in the MTG habit assemblage. These elements are "paratexts" (Consalvo, "When Paratexts Become Texts"; Apperley and Walsh) that frame the "text" of the game and shape how it will be played. Particularly noteworthy is the way in which they are records of others' play and thus also contain traces of a gameplay style or habitus that can be analysed. I emphasize here how paratexts are not merely discrete objects but are imbricated into an ensemble of practices and ways of making sense of a game. For Chord, he drew upon the 17lands.com data, his discussion with other players (in person, on forums, on live platforms like Twitch), his own gameplay experiences, and his review of materials produced by other content-creators (articles, videos, podcasts, draft logs, etc.). The existence of these sources, together with the community established practices concerning how they are used or interpreted, constitutes a habit or reflexivity assemblage for MTG players. It is an assemblage of techniques and technologies that shapes the specific form of reflexivity that players are able to marshal.

In order for a player to think about their own gameplay, they will need to *recall* their past drafts and games. Tools such a notepad or video recording enable players to track and then review the exact sequence of draft picks, plays, and draws in their games. The 17lands.com tracker has facilitated this in a streamlined way. Players can install it and use it to later view a record of all their draft picks as well as their plays in previous games. In Stiegler's terms (*Taking Care*), we can see a player's 17lands.com record, as "tertiary retention," acting on the "primary" and "secondary retention" of their draft pick orders by affecting or modifying their perception of the draft through repeated auditions (Roberts 58–59). These re-engagements with the draft record enable a player to envisage alternative possibilities that may not have occurred to them during the draft itself. They may then go on to discuss their thoughts with other members of the MTG community. Indeed, many share their draft logs. Discord channels are sites for these discussions, many of which receive input from the streamers who had created them as a reward for their Patreon subscribers.

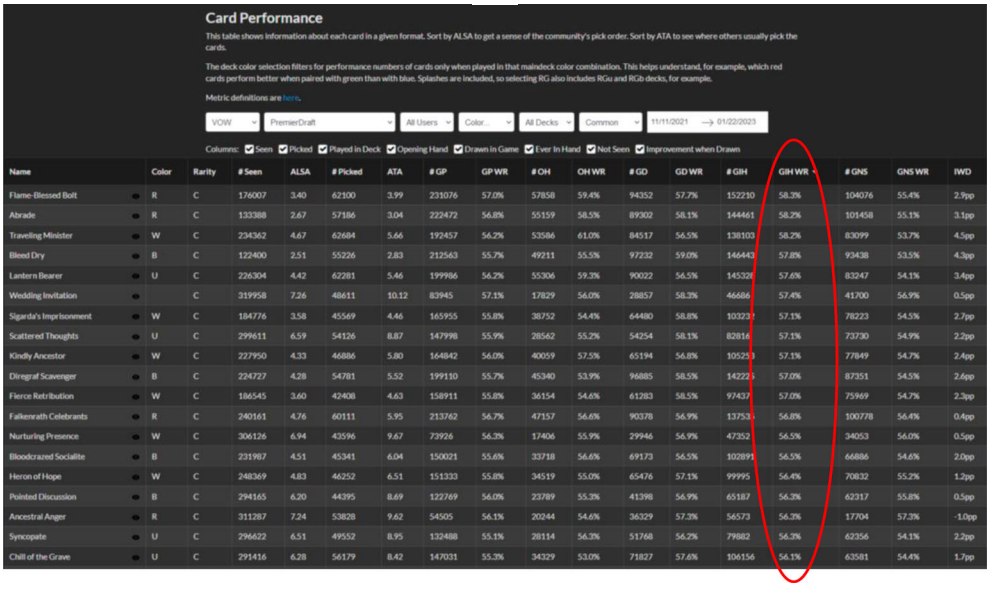
When a player encounters accounts of how the format has been navigated by *other* players, they can contrast with their own experiences. Synergies between cards that they had not noticed themselves might then be identified, leading them to drastically re-evaluate certain cards; misunderstandings concerning mechanics might be cleared up; or larger patterns concerning the "feel" of the format might chime with the player. All of these may work to prompt them to identify what their own approach or gamer habitus may be, and to question whether and how it needs to be

transformed (cf. Egliston). Watching streamers like Chord or Numot on Twitch or YouTube is a large part of this for many.

There will also be the consumption of content that is more ordered than a gameplay stream. Chord's aforementioned YouTube video on "big picture thoughts" falls into this category. In recent years, there has been quite an explosion in the commentary offered by professional players and streamers in the form of podcasts, streams, and videos. The Limited Resources podcast by LSV and Marshall Sutcliffe is one of the most popular. Websites like MTGA Zone, Draftsim, Card Kingdom, Star City Games, run regular articles. Ryan Saxe, a writer for Star City Games, creates exercises for readers in his articles: readers are shown a draft pick and asked to vote for which card to pick from it. Ryan then reveals his own reasoning. Often, this invites players to reconsider their own reasoning.

The use of metrics has seen a meteoric rise in popularity. It has been concentrated in the use of 17lands.com, which also aggregates and shares the data collected from players who have installed it (Figure 2). Increasingly, players will draft decks based on their interpretations of this data. One metric that has been favoured, as a means of designating the value of a card, is the Game in Hand Winrate (GIH WR) attributed to each card. It is the percentage of games won by the player with that card (e.g., Sigarda's Imprisonment) when it is in their opening hand or was later drawn in the game. That is, when the card was seen by the player and in principle playable, rather than being at the bottom of their deck. To make use of 17lands.com data, players will need to be able to sort the available data along desired parameters and to draw inferences from it, accounting for all the vicissitudes of player behaviour that formed this data in their interpretation of it.

Each of the above technologies comes together to constitute a material-semiotic *environment* in which players may draw upon pieces of information and repertoires of technologies or techniques to begin to problematize their own play and turn their gamer habitus into an object of knowledge with a view to its transformation (Foucault, "Technologies").[8] These techniques function to shape, but not



Card Performance

This table shows information about each card in a given format. Sort by ALSA to get a sense of the community's pick order. Sort by ATA to see where others usually pick the cards.

The deck color selection filters for performance numbers of cards only when played in that maindeck color combination. This helps understand, for example, which red cards perform better when paired with green than with blue. Splashes are included, so selecting RG also includes RGu and RGb decks, for example.

Metric definitions are here.

VOW | PremierDraft | All Users | Color... | All Decks | Common | 11/11/2021 → 01/22/2023

Columns: Seen | Picked | Played in Deck | Opening Hand | Drawn in Game | Ever In Hand | Not Seen | Improvement when Drawn

Name	Color	Rarity	# Seen	ALSA	# Picked	ATA	# GP	GP WR	# OH	OH WR	# GD	GD WR	# GIH	GIH WR	# GNS	GNS WR	IWD
Flame-Blessed Bolt	R	C	176007	3.40	62100	3.99	231076	57.0%	57858	59.4%	94352	57.7%	152210	58.3%	104076	55.4%	2.9pp
Abrade	R	C	133388	2.67	57186	3.04	222472	56.8%	55159	58.5%	89302	58.1%	144461	58.2%	101458	55.1%	3.1pp
Traveling Minister	W	C	234362	4.67	62684	5.66	192457	56.2%	53586	61.0%	84517	56.5%	138103	58.2%	83099	53.7%	4.5pp
Bleed Dry	B	C	122400	2.51	55226	2.83	212563	55.7%	49211	55.5%	97232	59.0%	146443	57.8%	93438	53.5%	4.3pp
Lantern Bearer	U	C	226304	4.42	62281	5.46	199986	56.2%	55306	59.3%	90022	56.5%	145328	57.6%	83247	54.1%	3.4pp
Wedding Invitation		C	319958	7.26	48611	10.12	83945	57.1%	17829	56.0%	28857	58.3%	46686	57.4%	41700	56.9%	0.5pp
Sigarda's Imprisonment	W	C	184776	3.58	45569	4.46	165955	55.8%	38752	54.4%	64480	58.8%	103233	57.1%	78223	54.5%	2.7pp
Scattered Thoughts	U	C	299611	6.59	54126	8.87	147998	55.9%	28562	55.2%	54254	58.1%	82816	57.1%	73730	54.9%	2.2pp
Kindly Ancestor	W	C	227950	4.33	46886	5.80	164842	56.0%	40059	57.5%	65194	56.8%	105253	57.1%	77849	54.7%	2.4pp
Diregraf Scavenger	B	C	224727	4.28	54781	5.52	199110	55.7%	45340	53.9%	96885	58.5%	142223	57.0%	87351	54.5%	2.6pp
Fierce Retribution	W	C	186545	3.60	42408	4.63	158911	55.8%	36154	54.6%	61283	58.5%	97437	57.0%	75969	54.7%	2.3pp
Falkenrath Celebrants	R	C	240161	4.76	60111	5.95	213762	56.7%	47157	56.6%	90378	56.9%	137533	56.8%	100778	56.4%	0.4pp
Nurturing Presence	W	C	306126	6.94	43596	9.67	73926	56.3%	17406	55.9%	29946	56.9%	47352	56.5%	34053	56.0%	0.5pp
Bloodcrazed Socialite	B	C	231987	4.51	45341	6.04	150021	55.6%	33718	56.6%	69173	56.5%	102891	56.5%	66886	54.6%	2.0pp
Heron of Hope	W	C	248369	4.83	46252	6.51	151333	55.8%	34519	55.0%	65476	57.1%	99995	56.4%	70832	55.2%	1.2pp
Pointed Discussion	B	C	294165	6.20	44395	8.69	122769	56.0%	23789	55.3%	41398	56.9%	65187	56.3%	62317	55.8%	0.5pp
Ancestral Anger	R	C	311287	7.24	53828	9.62	54505	56.1%	20244	54.6%	36329	57.3%	56573	56.3%	17704	57.3%	-1.0pp
Syncopate	U	C	296622	6.51	49552	8.95	132488	55.1%	28114	56.3%	51768	56.2%	79882	56.3%	62356	54.1%	2.2pp
Chill of the Grave	U	C	291416	6.28	56179	8.42	147031	55.3%	34329	53.0%	71827	57.6%	106156	56.1%	63581	54.4%	1.7pp

Fig. 2. 17lands.com data on card performance in VOW (common cards ranked by GIH WR from 11 November 2021 to 22 January 2023).

determine, how "thought works upon itself" in a particular form of practical reflexivity. It is the socio-technical basis that enable forms of reflexivity to arise. The reflexivity of MTG players, I argue, is inextricably interlinked to the way in which they synthesize, through a set of practices or techniques – rather than merely follow or imitate – the information available to them. In the next section I aim to describe some of the *general* features of the way in which Chord did so.

forms of elaboration

Chord's overall practice may be seen as that of vigilance in the face of the variance and contingency inherent within the game. In Foucauldian terms, these could be read as the "forms of elaboration" of the desiring subject (Foucault, *History*) – the way in which the subject constitutes itself, its habitus, and a form of reflexivity through its repeated practices that aim at meeting certain desires. There are several identifiable features. First, there is a vigilant hermeneutics of self-examination, in which the player works to identify their own gamer habitus into an object of knowledge. This likely takes place in introspective moments outside of the game, where the player pours over their draft picks and plays. Second, there is an agon of relentless trial by gameplay, in which repeated gameplay functions as the means of testing one's hypotheses and drawing conclusions. It is only through repetition that one can reduce the variance of good and bad draws, that the efforts of trying certain strategies can be better evaluated. Third, there is a studious attentiveness to new theories, in which the player remains informed about the new podcasts, articles, forum posts, etc. that emerge, some of which may herald glimpses of cards and strategies that have potential. Fourth, there is an experimental attitude, in which the player practices a willingness to try new approaches rather than stick to what is already known. It is certainly an experimentation within bounds, one where a limited number of ideas are tested at once, lest the outcomes be difficult to attribute to any specific approach. Fifth, there is a rigorous yet critical parsing of data, in which the player monitors the shifting landscape of 17lands.com.

It should be underscored how the complexity of drafting and playing the limited format means that the forms of elaboration and of reflexivity in the MTG habit assemblage are not codified but are contingent upon a whole series of questions that a player asks themselves. These are questions that often do not admit self-evident answers. MTG is a game of variance in which the best players can expect to win approximately 70 per cent of their games. The *im*probable can and does occur, and it can occur in succession. Players are therefore faced with the prospect, when they try to think in causal terms for the reasons behind their wins and losses, of how much it was due to variance (which they cannot control) and how much it was due to factors that they *can* control: the way they drafted and played. If causation is attributed to variance, then the player can tell themselves that nothing needs to be revised or changed for next time; hopefully, the difference will be that luck will be in greater abundance next time. But if causation is not primarily attributed to variance, then the player may be compelled to conclude that some aspect of their drafting or playing is ripe for re-examination and improvement. This process of reflection is something that is very familiar to limited players, although there may be significant discrepancies in the amount of time devoted to it by different players.

In deciding *whether* to problematize their "baseline" at all, players will likely attempt to extract general principles from the specific situations that they encountered in their games. The conclusion that one has not been taking removal highly enough is one that is arrived at from the synthesis of numerous gameplay positions and results. It is a judgement that is made after taking into consideration the background "noise" of the inherent variance in gameplay. Resultantly, the decision that it is necessary to shift "one's baseline" (or not) is so complex and so dependent upon players' particular lines of reasoning and sense-making

that different players will undoubtedly come to different conclusions even when reasoning about the same situation. Karhulahti has explored the "psycho-ludic" development of mastery-oriented individuals in contrast to non-mastery-oriented ones, the latter of which Schüll characterizes as seeking a state of comfort in a "zone" – she calls this "the opposite of deliberate practice" (97–98). It is likely that mastery-oriented players, like Chord, will frequently engage in problematization as part of their deliberate practice, which might occur in the wake of a string of losses. Not all players will maintain such vigilance. Thus, the form of reflexivity of the MTG habit assemblage is not codified but is characterized by the complexity of the game itself; the precise degree in which an individual player engages in the practice-based synthesis is not something that can be articulated in exact detail but it will be shaped, albeit not determined, by the habit assemblage. What results is that each player, by virtue of having a unique trajectory of experiences, internalizes a matchless combination of schemata in a recursive synthesis.

conclusion

The MTG habit assemblage does not prescribe "rules of conduct" (Foucault, *History* 12) but concerns the way in which individuals give "form to behaviour" (23). Thus, the player cannot directly draw on universal principles to determine their draft or their re-habituation but adopts "an attitude and a quest that individualized [their] action" (62). The way in which Chord gave form to his own behaviour surely spread to others though his gamer habitus cannot be imitated in its specificity. Although there is diversity, we may yet consider how habit assemblages direct and channel certain practices and forms of reflexivity, how they limit and constrain others, or even exclude some as unthinkable. In Bourdieu's words (*Logic* 55), this can be framed as how "the *habitus*, like every 'art of inventing,' is what makes it possible to produce an infinite number of practices that are *relatively unpredictable*" even if they are also "limited in their diversity."

This paper started from the premise that habits can exhibit intelligence, which led to an exploration of the intelligence of the MTG habit assemblage. We could understand habit assemblages as the "exteriorization" of thought (Stiegler, *Technics and Time 1*) and in terms of how the habitus is "the internalization of externality and the externalization of internality" in the form of "lasting dispositions, or trained capacities and patterned propensities to think, feel and act" (Wacquant, "Concise" 65). The way in which players bring their own gamer habitus into consciousness through techniques and technologies that constitute the assemblage could be said to be how the intelligence of the MTG habit assemblage operates to problematize itself. Chord, as a mastery-oriented player, practised a vigilant hermeneutics of self-examination; an agon of relentless trial by gameplay; a studious attentiveness to new theories; an experimental attitude; a rigorous yet critical parsing of data. These forms of elaboration are also forms of reflexivity; they were the conditions of possibility that led him to revise his "baseline" in VOW and to begin sedimenting new habits.

If habits give order to our perceptions and aid to filter some options out as "noise," then it is possible that the intelligence of the MTG habit assemblage means that anything in principle could potentially *become* noise (and vice versa). Thus, whilst particular cards might be initially filtered from players' attention, such as Sigarda's Imprisonment, they can, via re-habituation and the forms of reflexivity enabled by the MTG habit assemblage, later come to be highly picked by players. They would register prominently in players' perceptions in the moment that the draft cards are arrayed before them. Not only Chord but many other streamers revised their evaluations of "pacifism effect" cards for VOW, which no doubt cascaded into various consequences for the players who watched them, their gamer habitus, and the metagame itself. Indeed, I have previously argued that gamer habitus is characterized by its incessant reflexive practice

(Zhu, "Consciously Working"; "Ambivalence"; "Retraining") and that gaming can be seen to be a notable site on which individuals develop this contemporary "reflexive habitus" (Sweetman) or "accelerated reflexivity" (Papacharissi and Easton). Not only does gaming call for genre-specific and game-specific forms of gamer habitus, the changing metagame in many games requires players to continuously monitor and refine their play styles, and to do in a way that goes beyond merely consciously adopting certain play strategies. This flexibility may actually be the *overarching habitus* that a player has to the game over and above that of any *particular* transitory way of non-consciously intuiting, judging, reasoning, evaluating. Yet it is also not a boundless flexibility. In thinking about its limitations, we need to consider how it may be more challenging for the present forms of reflexivity in the MTG habit assemblage to initiate other kinds of transformations. Further work should address how these limitations might constitute an "unthought" of thought (Bogue 19), that which is not thinkable, and which would mark the limitations on the mutability or diversity of the material semiotic environment and the reflexivity it foments.

What more can be said about the significance of nurturing a flexible habitus that engages in the forms of reflexivity discussed? Beyond familiar critical perspectives that underline evermore intense forms of exploitation associated with our accelerated reflexivity, I would like to broach one other possibility. It has been said that the attentional style demanded by poetry (and indeed by any aesthetic attitude that is directed towards the world) is one that requires a capacity to tolerate situations of delayed categorization (Schaeffer, cited in Citton 151), as opposed to rushed or fixed categorizations. A context-sensitive delay in card valuation in MTG drafts that has been honed by the player's forms of elaboration and reflexivity can profoundly benefit the drafter. It is nurtured by players' experiences in engaging in subsequent re-evaluations of cards; they also learn to "stay open" for as long as they can in a draft before committing to any archetype and its concomitant play style. The ability to read the skeins of the progressing draft with a degree of detachment from any rigidly fixed valuation of particular cards is noteworthy in this regard since players are able to shift their filters in line with the context of their existing picks. To be clear, this is not a *hermeneutic* delay in categorization, as it is in poetry, but a practical one. It does not concern the meaning of certain words but the value or function of certain cards given the presence (and absence) of other cards. Yet the delay in categorization that is nurtured or entrained does perhaps bespeak an analogous capacity, one that would be in stark contrast to individuals gauging value by thinking strictly in terms of an identifiable market price that is thought to definitively reflect a "truth value" – a relation between the cost of production and extent of demand of the product, i.e., the shared market being a place for truth (see Schumpeter 215–17). Delayed categorization may mark a habitus that can shift its filters in response to the contingencies of the situation *even* more nimbly than any notion of a flexible habitus with accelerated reflexivity that has already been discussed in relation to contemporary subjectivity. Further, it may also herald the capacity and the propensity to gauge value outside of stable agreed upon market or community valuations. We can thus speculate on whether a vigilant care and concern for one's MTG gamer habitus are, among other things, also inroads towards this kind of subjectivity.[9]

disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

notes

1 See, for example, Bourdieu and Wacquant on "sociological reflexivity" (Hilgers; Wacquant, *Body and Soul*), through which the researcher has the capacity to explore the "unthought"

categories of thought, to plumb the social unconscious and to, as Hilgers puts it, attain a "freedom" after sociological revelation. See also Archer, who distilled a number of "modes of reflexivity" – four in total. These are: "communicative," "autonomous," "meta," and "fractured." Although these modes are said to be exercisable in a number of ways, critics have pointed out that she has put reflexivity as the cause of specific courses of action in such a way that underestimates how reflexivity is itself due to social process.

2 Although I use the term "object of knowledge" here, I keep open the possibility that the subject is involved in an ethopoetic self-constitution rather than a form of self-objectification involving the three modes of objectification that Foucault discussed: scientific classification, dividing practices, and subjectification. Foucault had expressly remarked that certain exercises involving the subject's "athletic kind of concentration" (such as ones mentioned by Marcus Aurelius and Plutarch), which did not in any way involve "either opening up the subject as a field of knowledge (*connaissances*) or undertaking the subject's exegesis and decipherment" (*Hermeneutics* 222). For him, these were much closer to Eugen Herrigel's account of how the archery master taught his students to aim for the target in *Zen and the Art of Archery*, i.e., a form of "spiritual practice." However, I do not want to impose any firm a priori division between these kinds of practices of the self – one kind being a form of objectification and the other not. Such a position is liable to lead to the concretization of rules in the pursuit of freedom, as against my preferred position that the degree of objectification can be deeply contingent on the specificity of their context and how practices are continued or altered over time. Thus, insofar as players *may* be involved in an ethopoetic self-constitution (as opposed to a self-objectification), their gameplay style may escape being rigidly fixed into an "object of knowledge" even though they attempt to grasp it (in some conceptual or more-than-conceptual way).

3 It is evident that forms of reflexivity manifest differently amongst players, which means that the shared MTG habit assemblage does not rigidly determine these reflexive practices. As such, I have used the term "shape" to denote a channelling or directing that falls short of determining; this is similar to the way that Bourdieu's conceptualization of "the field" enables for theorization of the differentiated nature of habitus within it (*Field*). This commitment still allows for the MTG habit assemblage functioning to set certain conditions of possibility for how thought is able to turn back on itself: how certain forms of reflexivity are made possible (or are more likely than others) while certain other forms may be precluded. I am grateful to Doug Stark for a conversation about determinism.

4 Ash has talked about this process as one of "attunement" when he discussed how videogames attune players as "complex assemblages of bodily capacities and cognitive processes" (34); Keogh has used the term "embodied literacy" (77); Galloway has drawn on "grammars of action"; Parisi has written insightfully on "ergonomic branding"; and Swalwell on "kinaesthetic knowledge."

5 Without espousing a strict mind/body dichotomy, a distinction that Stiegler has made is that between "psychotechniques" and "somatotechniques" (*Taking Care* 138).

6 On the parameters of any particular habitus, Wacquant has remarked that because habitus supplies at once a principle of sociation and individuation,

> one can speak of a masculine habitus, a bourgeois habitus, a national habitus, etc., corresponding to the major social "principles of vision and division," but also of an artistic habitus, a juridical habitus, a carceral habitus, etc., corresponding to specific institutions. ("Concise" 67)

Generally, it seems reasonable to think that a gamer habitus can apply to a certain *genre* of gaming that corresponds with a community (or field) rather than applying it too narrowly (to a particular game, even if it is *sui genesis*) or too broadly (to all gaming, given the multitude of game genres and actions that players practice). I believe that it is possible to give defensible justifications for what may seem like narrow or wide construals in light of a particular purpose. See also Jaćević's empirical studies of players.

7 Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_p8etZkWVNc&ab_channel=LimitedLevel-Ups.

8 Globally, there are undoubtedly distinct yet overlapping MTG habit assemblages due to the

barriers of language and the (in)accessibility of certain content to players, which means that not all players can be said to belong to a single MTG habit assemblage.

9 Further research on the habit assemblages of other games and their forms of reflexivity will grant us a more panoramic perspective concerning the role of other types of gaming in possibly adjacent forms of self-subjectification.

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